UNIVERSITY OF THE PEOPLE

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Assignment Unit 3

Submitted by: Mubashir Ali

Instructor: Darrel Van Hoose

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The Day Athens Fell: A Citizen’s Reckoning

Perspective: A Philosopher and Student of Socrates

Athens is quieter than I have ever known.

For years, the sound of oars striking the sea, soldiers marching through the streets, citizens arguing in the Assembly, and teachers questioning their students seemed to be the natural music of our city. Today, there is another sound: silence. Our long walls have been torn down; our fleet has been surrendered, and Sparta stands victorious. In 404 BCE, Athens lost more than a war. We have been forced to confront what we have become.

I cannot stop thinking about what my teacher Socrates once taught us: that a life without examination is not worth living. Perhaps this is the moment when Athens must finally examine itself.

We Athenians once celebrated our role in defeating Persia. The Persian Wars had shown that the Greek city-states could cooperate when faced with a powerful external enemy. The victories at places such as Marathon and Salamis gave Athen's confidence, especially because our navy became one of the most important instruments of Greek resistance. After the Persian threat, the Delian League was established to continue collective defense, and Athens became its leading power.

At first, this seemed like strength. Yet strength can become dangerous when it is no longer restrained by justice.

The League gradually became an instrument of Athenian power. Wealth and resources that had been gathered for collective security increasingly supported Athens and its ambitions. Our city grew richer and more powerful, but our allies increasingly had reason to fear us. We had fought Persia in the name of freedom, yet we began treating other Greeks as subjects rather than partners.

This contradiction troubles me more than our defeat.

The Peloponnesian War revealed the cost of our failure to control our ambitions. Athens and Sparta represented different forms of power. Athens possessed a formidable navy and maritime influence, while Sparta possessed a powerful land army and a network of allies. Their rivalry eventually produced a conflict that devastated both sides. Cartwright notes that the long struggle damaged the Greek world and ended with Sparta's victory after the destruction of the Athenian fleet at Aegospotami in 405 BCE.

But the war did not destroy Athens through one battle alone.

We suffered from disease, political division, military disasters, and the enormous cost of prolonged warfare. The plague that struck Athens during the early years of the war killed many citizens and even took Pericles. Later, our disastrous expedition to Sicily consumed ships, soldiers, and resources that Athens could not easily replace.

I ask myself whether we learned anything from these disasters.

Perhaps our greatest failure was believing that power itself was proof of wisdom.

Socrates would have questioned that assumption. To possess ships is not to possess justice. To command an empire is not to understand virtue. To win an argument in the Assembly is not necessarily to speak the truth. A city may become powerful while becoming morally confused.

Sparta, however, should not mistake victory for wisdom either.

The Spartans have defeated Athens, but what have they truly inherited? A weakened Greece, exhausted by years of conflict, is hardly a prize without a cost. The fall of Athens has not healed the wounds of the Greek world. It has exposed them. One city defeated another, yet neither discovered how to create lasting unity.

Our tragedy is therefore larger than Athens.

For generations, the polis was the center of Greek political and social life. Citizens identified themselves with their individual city-states, defended them, and competed with one another. Yet the wars between Athens and Sparta demonstrated how this division could become destructive. The Greek city-states had been capable of uniting against Persia, but they struggled to maintain that unity once the external enemy was gone.

Now I fear that the consequences will reach beyond our generation.

Already, the political balance of Greece is changing. Macedon is rising in the north under Philip II. The Greek city-states, weakened by years of conflict, are increasingly vulnerable to Macedonian power. Philip's military reforms and later expansion allowed Macedon to dominate Greece. His son Alexander would take this process much further, conquering the Persian Empire and creating an enormous realm.

Some Athenians will call this the end of Greek freedom.

Perhaps politically, they are right. The independent polis will no longer occupy the same position it once did. But I wonder whether Greek civilization is ending or changing.

Alexander's conquests will carry Greek language, philosophy, art, and customs far beyond the old boundaries of the Greek city-states. The Classical world of independent poleis will give way to a broader Hellenistic world in which Greek culture interacts with Egyptian, Persian, and other traditions.

If this is our future, then perhaps the final lesson of Athens is not that democracy was meaningless, or that power belongs to whoever has the strongest army. The lesson may be that political systems survive only when citizens continually examine the relationship between power and virtue.

Today, I mourned for Athens. I mourn the friends who died in battle, the citizens taken by disease, and the ideals we claimed to defend but sometimes betrayed. Yet I also believe that our ideas need not die with our walls.

The stones of Athens can be broken.

The questions cannot.

What is justice? What makes a good citizen? When does power become oppression? Can a society remain free without learning to restrain itself?

Socrates taught us to keep asking such questions.

So, as Athens falls, I will not say that everything we built has been lost. Our walls are gone, our fleet is defeated, and our political independence has been shattered. But if future generations continue to question power, seek truth, and examine the meaning of justice, then Athens may still have something to teach the world.

Perhaps that is what remains when a city falls: not its walls, but its questions.

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